

Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc.

Employee Handbook 2026

Leave, Attendance and Flexible Working Policies

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Internal Use Only

Prepared as a fictional source document for an HR/IT Knowledge Base Copilot project.

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1. Introduction and Purpose

1.1 About Meridian Harbor Technologies

Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc. ("Meridian Harbor", "MHT" or "the Company") is a logistics-software company headquartered in Port Alder, with approximately 1,800 employees across its Port Alder headquarters, the Northgate Operations Center and the Eastfield Customer Support Hub.

1.2 Purpose of This Handbook

This Handbook sets out the Company's policies on working hours, attendance, leave and flexible working for 2026. It exists to:

- Give every employee a clear, consistent understanding of their entitlements and obligations.
- Ensure leave and flexible working are applied fairly across all teams and locations.
- Give managers a single, authoritative reference for making decisions.
- Serve as the source of truth for HR queries, including those answered by the HR Knowledge Assistant.

1.3 Scope

This Handbook applies to all employees of Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc., subject to the eligibility rules in Section 7. It does not apply to independent contractors, consultants, agency workers or vendors. Parental, adoption and family leave are covered by the separate Family Leave Policy (HR-POL-07) and are not repeated here.

1.4 Guiding Principles

1. **Fairness:** Policies are applied consistently, without discrimination on the basis of any protected characteristic.
2. **Trust:** The Company trusts employees to manage their time responsibly and expects honest use of all leave types.
3. **Business continuity:** Employees and managers share responsibility for ensuring that customers and colleagues are not left unsupported.
4. **Wellbeing:** Employees are encouraged to use their leave and to stay home when unwell.

5. **Confidentiality:** Medical and personal information shared in connection with leave is handled strictly on a need-to-know basis.

1.5 Quick Reference Summary

Topic	Key Rule
Standard working week	40 hours, Monday to Friday
Default hours	9:00 AM to 5:30 PM (30-minute unpaid lunch)
Core hours	10:00 AM to 3:00 PM
Annual leave	20 to 30 days per year depending on years of service
Annual leave carry-over	Maximum 8 days, to be used by March 31
Sick leave	12 paid days per calendar year
Medical certificate required	From the 3rd consecutive sick day
Emergency leave	5 paid days per calendar year (bereavement is separate)
Work from home	Up to 2 days per week after probation; Tuesday and Wednesday are in-office anchor days
Probation period	90 calendar days
All leave requests	Submitted through the PeopleHub portal
Standard manager response time	2 working days (up to 5 days of leave)
HR Service Desk	hrsupport@meridianharbor.example, ext. 4400

2. Working Hours and Attendance

2.1 Standard Working Week

- The standard full-time working week is **40 hours**, worked Monday to Friday.
- The default working day runs from **9:00 AM to 5:30 PM**, including an unpaid lunch break of 30 minutes, giving **8 paid hours per day**.
- Employees are entitled to a lunch break of at least 30 minutes and no more than 60 minutes. A break longer than 30 minutes extends the working day accordingly.
- There must be a minimum rest period of **11 consecutive hours** between the end of one working day and the start of the next.

2.2 Flexible Start and Finish Times

- Employees may start work at any time between **7:30 AM and 10:00 AM**, provided they complete their full daily hours.
- All employees must be available during **core hours, 10:00 AM to 3:00 PM**, unless on approved leave.
- An employee's agreed start time must be recorded with their manager in PeopleHub. If no start time is recorded, the default start time of 9:00 AM applies.
- Changes to the agreed start time that last longer than two weeks require manager approval.

2.3 Shift-Based Roles

Employees in the Northgate Operations Center and the Eastfield Customer Support Hub who work on rostered shifts follow the shift pattern in their contract. Shift rosters are published at least **14 calendar days** in advance. Shift swaps between employees require manager approval at least 48 hours before the shift. Flexible start times and core hours do not apply to shift-based roles.

2.4 Recording Attendance

- Attendance is recorded in the **TimeTrack** system. Office-based employees badge in and out; remote workers log their start and finish times in TimeTrack.
- Employees must correct any missed or incorrect entries within **2 working days**. Managers approve timesheets by Friday 5:00 PM each week.
- Falsifying attendance records is treated as gross misconduct.

2.5 Lateness

- An employee is late if they arrive more than **10 minutes** after their agreed start time.
- Each employee has a grace allowance of **3 late arrivals of up to 10 minutes per calendar month**, which are not recorded as lateness.
- Lateness beyond the grace allowance is handled as follows:
 - **4th late arrival in a calendar month:** informal conversation with the manager.
 - **6 or more late arrivals in any rolling 90 days:** formal written warning under the Performance and Conduct Policy.
- Genuine disruption (such as severe weather or transport failure) is not counted as lateness if the employee informs their manager as early as possible.

2.6 Unplanned Absence and Notification

- An employee who cannot attend work must notify their manager **before their start time, and no later than 1 hour after it**, by phone call or direct message (email alone is not sufficient).
- Absence of **3 consecutive working days without any contact** is treated as unauthorized absence. After a written notice from HR giving 2 working days to respond, the Company may treat the employment as abandoned.

2.7 Overtime

Employees are classified as **exempt** or **non-exempt**, as shown on their contract.

	Non-exempt Employees	Exempt Employees
Eligible for overtime pay	Yes	No
Rate: weekdays and Saturdays beyond 40 hours	1.5 times base hourly rate	Not applicable
Rate: Sundays and Company holidays	2 times base hourly rate	Not applicable
Time off in lieu (TOIL) option	1.5 hours off per overtime hour worked, at the employee's request	1 working day off per full weekend or holiday day worked, with prior manager approval
Maximum overtime without Director approval	10 hours per week	Not applicable

- Overtime must be **approved in writing (through PeopleHub) before it is worked**. Hours that are worked but not pre-approved will still be paid, but may lead to a conversation about workload planning.
- TOIL must be taken within **60 calendar days** of being earned, or it lapses.

2.8 Company Holidays 2026

The Company observes **10 paid Company holidays** in 2026. Offices are closed on these days.

Date	Day	Holiday
January 1	Thursday	New Year's Day
April 3	Friday	Spring Recess Day
May 1	Friday	Labour Day
June 1	Monday	Founders' Day
July 3	Friday	Summer Holiday
September 7	Monday	Harvest Day
October 12	Monday	Autumn Day
December 24	Thursday	Year-End Closure (Day 1)
December 25	Friday	Year-End Closure (Day 2)
December 31	Thursday	Year-End Closure (Day 3)

Company holidays that fall during approved annual leave are **not deducted** from the annual leave balance. Shift-based employees required to work on a Company holiday are paid at the 2x rate or receive a day in lieu within 60 days.

3. Annual Leave

3.1 Leave Year

The leave year runs from **January 1 to December 31**.

3.2 Entitlement

Annual leave entitlement for full-time employees is based on **completed years of service as of January 1 of the leave year**.

Completed Years of Service (as of Jan 1)	Annual Leave (working days)
Less than 2 years	20 days
2 years to less than 5 years	23 days
5 years to less than 10 years	26 days
10 years or more	30 days

Example: An employee who joined on March 10, 2023 has 2 completed years of service on January 1, 2026 and therefore receives 23 days for 2026.

3.3 Accrual and Pro-Rating

- Leave accrues monthly at one-twelfth of the annual entitlement.

- **New joiners:** entitlement = tier entitlement x (remaining full months in the leave year / 12), rounded **up** to the nearest half day. *Example: A new joiner starting April 1 with a 20-day entitlement receives $20 \times 9/12 = 15$ days.*
- **Part-time employees:** entitlement = tier entitlement x (contracted weekly hours / 40).
- **Leavers:** leave is pro-rated to the last day of employment (see 3.9).

3.4 When Leave Can Be Taken

- Employees on probation may take accrued annual leave with manager approval, but not before completing **30 days** of service, and not more than **3 consecutive days** during probation.
- After probation, employees may use their full-year entitlement, including leave not yet accrued, subject to the advance leave rule in 3.8.
- Leave may be taken in increments of **half a day**.

3.5 Notice Requirements

Length of Leave Requested	Minimum Notice Required	Approver
0.5 to 2 working days	3 working days	Line manager
3 to 5 working days	10 working days	Line manager
6 to 10 working days	20 working days	Line manager
11 to 15 working days	40 working days	Line manager and Department Head
More than 15 consecutive working days	Not permitted without an exception (see Section 10)	Department Head, VP and HR

3.6 Blackout and Peak Periods

- Department Heads may designate up to **10 working days per year** as blackout periods, during which annual leave will normally not be approved (for example, quarter-end close in Finance or peak season in Logistics Operations).
- Blackout periods must be published to the team by **January 31** each year.
- Leave already approved before a blackout period is announced will not be withdrawn.

3.7 Carry-Over

- Up to **8 unused days** may be carried over into the next leave year.
- Carried-over days must be used by **March 31**. Any days not used by then are forfeited, unless an exception has been approved (see Section 10).
- Unused leave above the carry-over limit is forfeited on December 31.
- The maximum total annual leave balance at any time is **40 days**.

3.8 Advance Leave

Employees who have completed probation may request up to **3 days** of annual leave in advance of accrual, with HR approval. If employment ends before the leave is earned, the equivalent amount may be deducted from final pay.

3.9 Payment for Unused Leave

- Annual leave **cannot be exchanged for cash** during employment.
- On leaving the Company, accrued but unused leave (up to a maximum of **30 days**) is paid at the daily rate, calculated as **annual base salary / 260**.

3.10 Minimum Leave Requirement

Every employee must take at least **5 consecutive working days** of annual leave at some point each year, for wellbeing and risk-management reasons. Managers should monitor this and encourage employees who have not booked leave by **September 30** to do so.

3.11 Leave Interrupted by Illness

If an employee falls ill during approved annual leave and provides a medical certificate covering the period, the affected days are credited back to the annual leave balance and treated as sick leave, provided the employee notifies their manager on the first day of illness.

4. Sick Leave

4.1 Entitlement

- Full-time employees receive **12 paid sick days per calendar year**, paid at 100% of base salary.
- Part-time employees receive 12 x (contracted weekly hours / 40) days.
- New joiners receive **1 day for each full month remaining in the calendar year** (up to 12 days) and may use it from their first day of employment.
- Sick leave may be taken in half-day increments.

4.2 What Counts as Sick Leave

Sick leave covers physical illness, injury, **mental health conditions**, recovery from medical procedures and the following:

- **Family care:** Up to **3 days per year** of an employee's sick leave entitlement may be used to care for a spouse or partner, child or parent who is ill. This is counted against the employee's 12 days.
- **Medical appointments:** Employees may take up to **4 hours per appointment, to a maximum of 16 hours per year**, for medical or dental appointments without any deduction, provided they give at least 2 working days' notice where possible. Time beyond these limits is deducted from sick leave in half-day increments.

4.3 Reporting Sickness

1. Notify the line manager **before the start time, and no later than 1 hour after it**, by phone call or direct message.
2. Provide the expected return date, if known. For absences longer than one day, update the manager daily unless a medical certificate already covers the period.
3. Record the absence in PeopleHub within **24 hours of returning** to work.

4.4 Medical Certificates

Length of Absence	Documentation
1 to 2 consecutive working days	No certificate required; self-certify in PeopleHub
3 or more consecutive working days	Medical certificate required, submitted within 3 working days of returning
Any sick day immediately before or after a Company holiday or approved annual leave	Medical certificate required
Absence connected to a planned procedure	Certificate or doctor's letter submitted in advance

Employees are never required to disclose a diagnosis to their manager. The certificate should confirm only the dates of unfitness for work, and is submitted to HR rather than to the line manager.

4.5 Return-to-Work Conversation

A short, supportive return-to-work conversation is held by the manager when an employee:

- has been absent for **5 or more consecutive working days**; or
- has had **4 or more separate sickness absences in a rolling 6-month period**.

The purpose is to check on wellbeing and identify any support or adjustments needed, not to apply disciplinary pressure.

4.6 Carry-Over

Up to **5 unused sick days** may be carried forward to the next calendar year. The maximum sick leave available in any year is therefore **17 days**. Unused sick leave is not paid out on leaving the Company.

4.7 Extended Medical Leave

Employees with at least **12 months of service** who exhaust their sick leave may apply for Extended Medical Leave:

Stage	Duration	Pay
Stage 1	Up to 60 working days	60% of base salary
Stage 2	Up to a further 60 working days	Unpaid

- A medical certificate is required, renewed at least every 30 days.
- Applications are reviewed by HR and approved within **5 working days**.
- Job protection applies for a maximum of **120 working days** from the first day of Extended Medical Leave.
- Health insurance and pension contributions continue during Stage 1. During Stage 2, the employee continues benefits by paying their own share of the premium.
- Employees returning from extended leave are offered a phased return of up to **4 weeks** where medically recommended.

4.8 Misuse of Sick Leave

Using sick leave dishonestly, including working elsewhere while on sick leave or providing false documentation, is gross misconduct and may result in dismissal.

5. Emergency Leave

5.1 Purpose

Emergency leave provides paid time off for urgent, unforeseeable situations that require an employee's immediate attention and cannot reasonably be handled outside working hours.

5.2 Entitlement

- Full-time employees receive **5 paid emergency leave days per calendar year**, available from the first day of employment and not pro-rated for new joiners.
- Part-time employees receive 3 days.
- Emergency leave cannot be carried over and is not paid out on leaving.
- Each separate emergency is limited to **3 consecutive working days**. Longer periods may be covered with annual leave, or with unpaid leave (see 5.5).

5.3 Qualifying Emergencies

- Sudden hospitalization, serious accident or critical illness of a spouse or partner, child, parent, sibling or dependent.
- Serious damage to the employee's home (fire, flood, burst pipe, break-in) requiring their immediate presence.
- Unexpected loss of childcare or dependent care, such as the sudden closure of a school or care facility.
- Natural disasters, severe weather events or government-ordered evacuations affecting the employee's ability to travel safely.
- Urgent legal or police matters involving the employee as a victim or witness.

Routine matters such as planned appointments, repairs that can be scheduled or minor transport delays are **not** emergencies.

5.4 Bereavement Leave (Separate from Emergency Leave)

Bereavement leave is a separate entitlement and **does not reduce** the 5 emergency days.

Relationship to Employee	Paid Days per Event
Spouse or partner, child, parent, sibling, grandparent	5 working days
Parent-in-law, grandchild	3 working days
Aunt, uncle, niece, nephew, other in-laws, close friend	1 working day

- An additional **2 working days** of travel time are granted where the funeral or related arrangements are more than **500 km** from the employee's home.
- Bereavement leave may be taken in separate blocks within **30 calendar days** of the date of death.

5.5 Unpaid Emergency Leave

After the paid emergency days are used, employees may request up to **5 further unpaid days** per year with HR approval. Employees may alternatively request to use annual leave.

5.6 Notification and Documentation

- Notify the line manager **as soon as possible and within 2 hours of the normal start time**.
- Record the leave in PeopleHub within **2 working days** of returning.
- Supporting documentation must be provided within **5 working days** of returning, for example: a funeral notice or death certificate, a hospital letter, an insurer's or utility's incident report, or a school or care facility closure notice.
- Where documentation cannot reasonably be obtained, HR may accept a written statement from the employee.

5.7 Approval

Managers review and approve emergency leave within **2 working days** of the request being recorded. Managers should not delay or condition approval on documentation while the employee is dealing with the emergency itself. Repeated or unsupported use of emergency leave is reviewed by HR and may lead to a formal conversation.

6. Work From Home

6.1 Hybrid Working Model

Meridian Harbor operates a **hybrid working model** for roles identified as hybrid-eligible. Employees are expected to spend most of their time in the office to support collaboration, onboarding and culture.

- Eligible employees may work from home up to **2 days per week**.

- **Tuesday and Wednesday are in-office anchor days** for all hybrid employees. Regular work-from-home days are therefore normally Monday, Thursday or Friday.
- Remote work is arranged with the line manager, who agrees a fixed weekly pattern, recorded in PeopleHub.
- Roles that are designated **fully remote** are identified as such on the employee's offer letter and approved by a Vice President.

6.2 Eligibility Conditions

To work from home, an employee must:

1. Hold a role designated hybrid-eligible by the Department Head. Roles that require physical presence (for example, facilities, warehouse operations, hardware labs and shift-based customer support) are not eligible.
2. Have **completed probation** (90 days). See 6.3 for new joiners.
3. Have a current performance rating of **"Meets Expectations" or above**.
4. Have **no active written warning**.
5. Have a suitable, safe and private workspace, with a reliable internet connection of at least **50 Mbps download and 10 Mbps upload**.
6. Have completed the annual Information Security and Remote Working training module.

6.3 New Joiners

- During the first **30 days**: in the office 5 days per week.
- Days **31 to 90**: up to **1 day per week** of working from home, with manager approval.
- After probation: the standard 2 days per week, if the eligibility conditions are met.

6.4 Working From Home Expectations

- Be available and contactable during **core hours (10:00 AM to 3:00 PM)** and keep status and calendar up to date in the Company chat tool.
- Work the same number of contracted hours as in the office.
- Join video meetings with camera on, unless there is a connectivity or privacy reason.
- Be able to attend the office at short notice (within 2 hours) for urgent business needs, where the home is within commuting distance.
- Use only Company-issued equipment, connect through the Company **VPN**, and never use public Wi-Fi without it.
- Keep confidential material secure, use screen locks, and do not print confidential documents at home.
- Report loss or theft of any Company device to IT Security within **1 hour**.

6.5 Requests for Additional or One-Off Days

- **Day swaps**: An employee may swap a regular WFH day for another day in the same week with notice to their manager by **5:00 PM the previous working day**.
- **Flex days**: Employees may request up to **6 additional WFH days per year** beyond their regular pattern. Requests must be submitted by **5:00 PM the previous working day**, and managers respond by **12:00 noon** that day.
- **Emergency WFH**: In the event of severe weather, public transport strikes or building closures, employees may work from home with notification to their manager, provided it is practical to do so. These days do not count toward the flex day limit.

6.6 Work From Anywhere

- Employees may work temporarily from another city or country for up to **10 working days per calendar year**.
- Requests must be submitted at least **4 weeks in advance** and approved by the manager, the Department Head and HR (for tax, legal and security reasons).
- Approval is not guaranteed and may be declined for legal or security reasons.
- Working from abroad outside this arrangement is not permitted.

6.7 Equipment and Allowances

Item	Hybrid Employees	Fully Remote Employees
Company laptop	Yes	Yes
One-time home office stipend	USD 400, after 6 months of eligible hybrid working	USD 600 on starting
Monthly internet and utilities allowance	USD 30	USD 60
Loan of monitor, keyboard and mouse	On request	Yes

Stipends are paid through payroll as taxable income unless local rules state otherwise. Equipment remains Company property and must be returned within **10 working days** of leaving the Company or of ceasing to work from home.

6.8 Sick or Unwell While Working From Home

Employees who are unwell should take sick leave and should not be expected to work. Working from home is not a substitute for sick leave.

6.9 Changing or Withdrawing Arrangements

- Work-from-home arrangements are reviewed every **6 months**.
- A manager may change or withdraw an arrangement with **10 working days' notice** where business needs, performance or team collaboration require it.
- Arrangements may be withdrawn **immediately** in the event of a security breach, a conduct issue or an active written warning.
- Employees may appeal to their HR Business Partner within **5 working days**.

7. Employee Eligibility

7.1 Employee Categories

Category	Definition
Full-time permanent	Permanent employee contracted for 40 hours per week
Part-time permanent	Permanent employee contracted for 20 to 39 hours per week
Fixed-term	Employee on a contract with a defined end date of 6 months or more
Short-term fixed	Contract of less than 6 months
Intern / Trainee	Employee on a formal internship or training programme
Contractor / Consultant	Independent individual or agency worker (not covered by this Handbook)

7.2 Probation

- All new permanent and fixed-term employees serve a **90 calendar day probation period**.
- Probation may be extended **once**, for up to **30 calendar days**, with written notice to the employee before the end of the original probation period.
- During probation, either party may end employment with **7 calendar days' notice**.

7.3 Eligibility Matrix

Entitlement	Full-time	Part-time	Fixed-term (6+ months)	Short-term fixed (under 6 months)	Intern
Annual leave	Full tier entitlement	Pro-rated by hours	Pro-rated by contract length	1.5 days per month worked	1 day per month worked
Sick leave	12 days	12 x (hours/40)	Pro-rated by contract length	1 day per month worked	1 day per month worked (max 4 per 6 months)
Emergency leave	5 days	3 days	5 days	2 days	2 days
Bereavement leave	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Extended Medical Leave	After 12 months	After 12 months	No	No	No
Work from home	After probation	After probation	After probation	Manager discretion	Up to 1 day per week at manager discretion
Work From Anywhere	After probation	After probation	After probation	No	No
Overtime	Per classification	Per classification	Per classification	Per classification	Not permitted
Company holidays	Yes	Pro-rated by hours	Yes	Yes	Yes

7.4 Service Calculation

- **Years of service** are calculated from the employee's Continuous Service Date, as recorded in PeopleHub.
- Periods of unpaid leave longer than 30 consecutive days do not count towards service for the purpose of annual leave tiers.
- Employees who return to the Company within **12 months** of leaving retain their original service date for leave purposes.
- Fixed-term employees converted to permanent contracts retain continuous service.

8. Request and Approval Process

8.1 Where to Submit

All leave and work-from-home requests are submitted through **PeopleHub** (peoplehub.meridianharbor.example). Requests made by email, chat or verbally are not valid until entered into PeopleHub. In an emergency, the employee notifies the manager directly and records the request afterwards.

8.2 Request Status

Status	Meaning
Pending	Submitted and awaiting a decision
Approved	Confirmed; the employee may proceed
Rejected	Declined with a stated reason
Cancelled	Withdrawn by the employee or the Company

8.3 Summary of Timelines

Request Type	Submit	Approver	Decision Timeline	Documentation
Annual leave, up to 5 days	Per notice table in 3.5	Line manager	Within 2 working days	None
Annual leave, 6 to 10 days	At least 20 working days ahead	Line manager	Within 5 working days	None
Annual leave, 11 to 15 days	At least 40 working days ahead	Line manager and Department Head	Within 5 working days	None
Sick leave	Notify before or within 1 hour of start; record within 24 hours of return	Line manager (records only)	Not applicable	Certificate from 3rd consecutive day
Extended Medical Leave	As soon as the need is known	HR	Within 5 working days	Medical certificate
Emergency leave	Notify within 2 hours of start; record within 2 working days of return	Line manager	Within 2 working days	Within 5 working days of return
Regular WFH arrangement	Any time after eligibility	Line manager	Within 5 working days	None
Flex day / day swap	By 5:00 PM the previous working day	Line manager	By 12:00 noon the same day	None
Work From Anywhere	At least 4 weeks ahead	Manager, Department Head and HR	Within 10 working days	Destination and dates
Overtime	Before the work is done	Line manager	Within 1 working day	None

8.4 Step-by-Step Process

1. **Check your balance** and the team calendar in PeopleHub.
2. **Submit the request**, including dates, leave type and any cover arrangements.
3. **Manager review**: the manager approves or rejects within the timelines above. Rejections must include a written reason.

- 4. **Confirmation:** the employee receives an automated notification, and approved leave appears in the team calendar.
- 5. **Handover:** the employee arranges cover and sets an out-of-office message before going on leave.

8.5 Escalation When No Decision Is Made

- If a manager has not responded within **3 working days** of submission, PeopleHub escalates the request automatically to the manager's own manager.
- If there is still no decision within **5 working days** of the original submission, the HR Business Partner decides the request.
- Requests are **never** approved automatically by silence.

8.6 Competing Requests

- Requests are normally approved in the order they were submitted (by PeopleHub timestamp).
- For popular periods, such as the summer holidays and year end, managers should aim for fair rotation, giving priority to those who did not receive their preferred period the previous year.
- Not more than **30% of a team (and at least 1 person)** should be on annual leave at the same time, unless the manager is confident that coverage is not affected.

8.7 Changes and Cancellations

- Employees may amend or cancel approved leave at least **2 working days** before the start date. Later changes require manager approval.
- The Company may recall an employee from approved leave only in a genuine, business-critical situation, with at least **10 working days' notice** where possible. The Company reimburses documented non-refundable costs.
- Recalled leave is reinstated to the employee's balance.

8.8 Appeals

An employee whose request was rejected may appeal in writing to their Department Head and HR within **5 working days**. HR provides a final decision within **5 working days** of receiving the appeal.

8.9 Unauthorized Absence

Leave that has not been approved, other than sick leave or emergency leave, is treated as unauthorized absence. This is a conduct matter and may result in unpaid deduction and disciplinary action.

9. Manager Responsibilities

9.1 Timely Decisions

Managers must:

- Respond to leave requests within the timelines in Section 8.
- Provide a clear, written reason for every rejection and, where possible, suggest alternative dates.
- Not hold requests in "Pending" status to avoid making a decision.

9.2 Fair and Consistent Treatment

- Apply policies consistently to all team members without favoritism or discrimination.
- Not refuse leave for reasons relating to an employee's personal circumstances, protected characteristics, or because they have recently taken leave.

- Ensure that reasonable adjustments are considered for employees with disabilities or health conditions (see Section 10).

9.3 Workload and Coverage

- Maintain a shared team calendar and plan coverage for critical tasks.
- Ensure that no more than 30% of a team is on leave at the same time, as set out in 8.6.
- Encourage team members to take their full annual leave, including the minimum **5 consecutive days**. Managers must remind employees with unused leave by **September 30** each year.
- Never pressure an employee to cancel or shorten approved leave, and avoid contacting employees on leave except in genuine emergencies.

9.4 Attendance and Absence Management

- Record team attendance and approve timesheets by Friday 5:00 PM each week.
- Hold a **return-to-work conversation** after any absence of 5 or more consecutive days, or after 4 or more separate sickness absences in a rolling 6 months (see 4.5).
- Handle lateness and attendance concerns promptly, privately and consistently with 2.5.
- Report suspected misuse of leave, or an unexplained pattern of absence, to HR within **3 working days**. Managers must not investigate or confront the employee on their own.

9.5 Confidentiality

- Never ask for a diagnosis or detailed medical information.
- Keep medical certificates and personal circumstances confidential. Share them only with HR, and with others only where strictly necessary.
- Do not discuss one employee's leave, absence or health with other team members.

9.6 Managing Work From Home

- Agree the weekly work-from-home pattern with each eligible team member and ensure that the two in-office anchor days are respected.
- Review each arrangement every 6 months.
- Judge remote employees on results and contribution, not on visibility.
- Ensure team members complete the annual security and remote working training.

9.7 Training and Accountability

- All people managers must complete "**People Manager Essentials**" training within **90 days** of becoming a manager, and refresher training each year by **March 31**.
- Managers who consistently miss approval deadlines will be reported to their Department Head. HR reviews compliance with response times quarterly.

10. Exceptions

10.1 General Principles

Exceptions to the policies in this Handbook may be granted in genuine, exceptional circumstances. Exceptions:

- must be requested in advance wherever possible;
- are decided case by case and **do not set a precedent**;

- are time-limited, normally for no longer than **12 months**;
- cannot override legal minimum entitlements or the Code of Conduct.

10.2 How to Request an Exception

1. Complete the **Policy Exception Request form (HR-EX-01)** in PeopleHub, giving the reason, the policy affected and the period requested.
2. The line manager adds a recommendation and submits it to HR within **2 working days**.
3. The HR Business Partner and the relevant Department Head (or VP, for requests involving more than 5 days) review the request.
4. A written decision is given within **7 working days** of the request reaching HR.
5. Approved exceptions are recorded in PeopleHub.

10.3 Common Exceptions

Situation	Possible Exception	Approver
Business-critical project prevented leave being used	Up to 5 additional carry-over days (13 in total), to be used by June 30	Department Head and HR
Employee wants more than 15 consecutive days of annual leave	Up to 30 consecutive working days (for example for extended travel or family reasons), partly unpaid if the balance is insufficient	VP and HR
Medical condition or disability	Reasonable adjustments, including additional remote working days, adjusted hours or a phased return. Handled confidentially, with medical evidence	HR (Employee Relations)
Religious observance	Up to 3 days per year off, taken as annual leave, which cannot be refused for blackout periods, or as unpaid leave	HR
Exhausted sick leave without 12 months of service	Up to 20 working days of unpaid, job-protected leave	HR
Employee needs to relocate temporarily for family reasons	Work From Anywhere for up to 30 working days	VP and HR
Jury duty, military reserve, or other legal civic service	Leave as required by law, with pay as stated in the applicable law	HR

10.4 Exceptions Not Available

The Company cannot grant exceptions that:

- cash out annual leave during employment;
- allow work from another country for longer than permitted by tax, immigration or security rules;
- remove the medical certificate requirement for fitness-for-work in safety-critical roles.

10.5 Other Policies

Parental, adoption and family leave are governed by the **Family Leave Policy (HR-POL-07)**. Unpaid career breaks are governed by the **Career Break Policy (HR-POL-11)**.

11. HR Support

11.1 HR Service Desk

Channel	Details
Email	hrsupport@meridianharbor.example
Phone	+1 (555) 010-4400 (ext. 4400)
Portal	PeopleHub > "Ask HR"
In person	HR Service Desk, 3rd Floor, Harbor Tower, 200 Quayside Avenue, Port Alder
Hours	Monday to Friday, 8:30 AM to 5:00 PM

11.2 Response Standards

- **Acknowledgement** of every query within **1 working day**.
- **Resolution** of standard queries within **3 working days**.
- **Resolution** of complex queries (for example, exceptions, extended medical leave or legal questions) within **5 working days**, with progress updates.
- **Urgent matters** (such as a bereavement, a safety concern or a pay error affecting the next payroll) are prioritized, with a response within **4 working hours**.

11.3 Specialist Contacts

Area	Contact
Leave and attendance queries	hrsupport@meridianharbor.example
Payroll and overtime	payroll@meridianharbor.example
Benefits and Extended Medical Leave	benefits@meridianharbor.example
Employee Relations (complaints, adjustments, appeals)	employeeerelations@meridianharbor.example
IT Security (lost or stolen device)	itsecurity@meridianharbor.example, +1 (555) 010-4500 (24 hours)
Anonymous Ethics Line	ethicsline.meridianharbor.example, or +1 (555) 010-4999 (24 hours, run by an independent provider)

11.4 Employee Assistance Programme

All employees and their immediate family members have free, confidential access to the Employee Assistance Programme (EAP), which provides up to **6 counselling sessions per issue per year**, 24 hours a day, at +1 (555) 010-4888. Use of the EAP does not need manager approval and is not reported to the Company.

11.5 HR Business Partners

Each department has a named HR Business Partner, listed in PeopleHub under "My Team > HR Contacts". HR Business Partners provide advice to managers and employees, decide escalated requests and handle appeals.

12. Document Information

Item	Detail
Document title	Employee Handbook 2026: Leave, Attendance and Flexible Working
Document reference	HR-HB-2026
Version	2026.1
Owner	Human Resources, Chief People Officer
Approved by	Chief People Officer and Executive Leadership Team
Effective date	February 1, 2026
Supersedes	Employee Handbook 2025 (version 2025.2)
Review cycle	Annual (next review due by December 1, 2026)
Applies to	All employees of Meridian Harbor Technologies, Inc. (see Section 7)
Confidentiality	Internal use only

12.1 Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
2025.2	June 10, 2025	Updated WFH allowance and flex day rules
2026.1	January 15, 2026	Annual refresh: added tenure tier for 10+ years (30 days), introduced Work From Anywhere (10 days), increased carry-over to 8 days, clarified bereavement leave as separate from emergency leave, added Extended Medical Leave stages

12.2 Related Documents

- Family Leave Policy (HR-POL-07)
- Career Break Policy (HR-POL-11)
- Performance and Conduct Policy (HR-POL-03)
- Information Security Policy (IT-POL-01)
- Code of Conduct

12.3 Disclaimer

This Handbook is a guide to Company policy and does not form part of any employment contract. The Company may amend it at any time, with notice to employees. Where local law gives more favorable rights than those in this Handbook, local law applies. If there is any conflict between this Handbook and an individual contract of employment, the contract takes precedence. For anything not covered, contact the HR Service Desk.

Department: HR

Document Type: Employee Handbook

Last Updated: January 15, 2026